

Relative clauses

ALSO KNOWN AS ADJECTIVE CLAUSES, RELATIVE CLAUSES MODIFY NOUNS.

Relative clauses add information to a sentence using the relative pronouns *who*, *whom*, *whose*, *that*, and *which*. Restrictive relative clauses add essential details, while nonrestrictive clauses add nonessential details.

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• Make sure that the **relative clause** is **next** to the **noun** or **pronoun** that it is **modifying**. Otherwise, it may end up modifying the wrong person or thing.

• Sometimes a relative clause can be used to **modify the rest of the sentence**, rather than a single noun or pronoun. In the following sentence, the relative clause is describing the whole first part of the sentence: “Joe did not look sorry, **which was normal**.”

Nonrestrictive relative clauses

There are two types of relative clauses: nonrestrictive and restrictive. Also known as “nondefining” or “nonessential” clauses, nonrestrictive relative clauses offer additional information about a noun. They are separated from the rest of a sentence by commas, because the information they provide is supplementary, rather than essential.

Nonrestrictive clauses require commas.

The principal, **who** hated chaos, felt calm.

This nonrestrictive relative clause gives more detail about the principal, but it can be removed without affecting the meaning of the sentence.

The principal, **who** hated chaos, felt Joe, **whom** he had summoned. Joe

Relative pronouns

Relative clauses always follow the noun or pronoun that they modify. They start with one of five relative pronouns, which act as either the subject or the object of the relative clause. *Who* always acts as the subject, while *whom* always acts as the object. The relative pronouns *who*, *whom*, and *whose* are used to refer to people, while *which* and *that* are used to refer to things.

This is the object of the relative clause—the person who was summoned.

whom he had summoned

This is the subject of the relative clause.

who hated chaos

This is the subject of the relative clause—the person who hated chaos.

This is the object of the relative clause.